Emotional Freedom Techniques

A guide to tapping for nervous system regulation

WHAT IT IS

EFT Tapping

Emotional Freedom Techniques — tapping — combines gentle fingertip contact on acupressure points with focused awareness of a feeling, memory, or belief. It works by sending a calming signal to your amygdala — the brain's threat centre — while holding the stressor in mind.

The result: your nervous system learns this thing is no longer a threat. Not through willpower. Through sensation and repetition at a physiological level.

THE SCIENCE

Why it works

Calms the amygdala

Sends a direct physiological safety signal — bypassing the thinking mind entirely.

Lowers cortisol

Research shows EFT reduces cortisol significantly, often in a single session.

Rewires the stress response

Repeated tapping on a specific issue weakens the neural pathway linking that trigger to fear.

Works on the root

Unlike breathing alone, tapping lets you stay present with discomfort while neutralising it.

BEFORE YOU START

What beginners need to know

One issue at a time.

The more specific your focus, the faster the shift. Tap on 'this tightness in my chest when I think about money' — not 'my life.'

Expect layers.

Some issues clear in one round. Others have layers — each round peels one back. A drop from 8 to 5 is real progress. Keep going.

You can tap either side.

Most points exist on both sides of the body. Tap one side or alternate — there is no wrong choice.

Use two or three fingertips.

Index and middle fingers together cover more surface area. Exact placement matters less than consistent contact and attention.

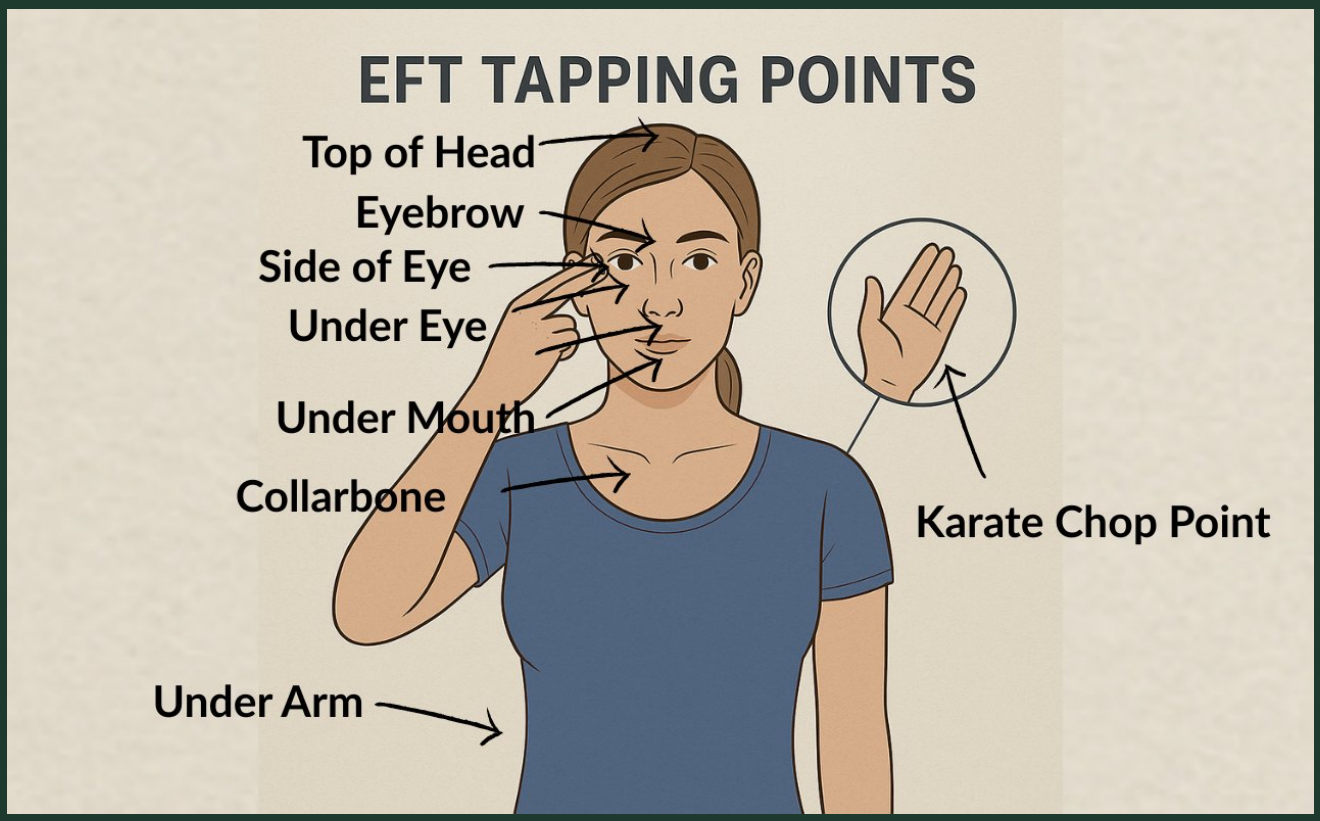
Physical releases are normal.

Yawning, sighing, a wave of tiredness, or warmth are signs your nervous system is releasing. They are the work happening.

It does not have to make sense.

Skepticism is fine. The mechanism is physiological — you are sending a calming signal to your amygdala regardless of what your rational mind thinks. Tap anyway.

THE TAPPING POINTS



POINT REFERENCE

1 **KC** Karate Chop
Side of hand, below the pinky

2 **EB** Eyebrow
Inner edge of eyebrow, above the nose

3 **SE** Side of Eye
Outer corner of eye socket, on the bone

4 **UE** Under Eye
Directly under the pupil, on the cheekbone

5 **UN** Under Nose
Groove between nose and upper lip

6 **CH** Chin
Midpoint of the chin crease

7 **CB** Collarbone
Just below and beside the sternum notch

8 **UA** Under Arm
4 inches below the armpit, side of torso

9 **TH** Top of Head
Crown of head, centre

BEFORE YOU TAP

The setup statement

Every round begins with a setup statement. While tapping the karate chop point continuously, say this phrase three times out loud. It does two things simultaneously: it names the problem honestly, and it offers self-acceptance alongside it. Your nervous system needs both.

FORMULA

"Even though I feel [this specific thing], I deeply and completely accept myself."

Example: "Even though I feel this anxiety about money, I deeply and completely accept myself."

THE PROCESS

How to do a round

Each round has two distinct sections. The setup statement comes first — it orients your nervous system to the issue and establishes safety. The reminder phrases come second — they keep your attention on the feeling as you move through each tapping point.

01 Identify

Name what you are feeling and where you feel it in your body. Be specific — vague problems get vague results.

02 Rate it 0–10

Give the intensity a number before you start. Ten is overwhelming, zero is completely neutral. This is your baseline.

03 Setup statement

Tap the karate chop point continuously while saying your setup statement three times out loud. This is section one of the round.

04 Reminder phrases

Move through all 9 points, 5–7 taps each. Say a short honest phrase at each point that names the feeling. This is section two.

05 Breathe and check

Take a slow breath. Notice what has shifted. Rate the intensity again on a scale of 0–10.

06 Repeat or close

If the intensity is above 3, do another full round. If it is below 3, close with a positive round — tap through the points saying what you want to feel instead.

REMINDER PHRASES

A full round — stress

Below is a complete example. The setup statement is said three times on the karate chop point before moving through the sequence.

SETUP STATEMENT ×3 — karate chop point

"Even though I feel this stress in my body, I deeply and completely accept myself."

Eyebrow	*"This stress in my body"*
Side of eye	*"I feel so overwhelmed"*
Under eye	*"It is all too much right now"*
Under nose	*"This tension I am carrying"*
Chin	*"I cannot seem to switch off"*
Collarbone	*"My nervous system is overloaded"*
Under arm	*"But I have got through hard days before"*
Top of head	*"I am allowing my body to find calm"*

AFTER THE ROUND

Calibrate and continue

Take a breath. Rate your intensity again on a scale of 0–10 and compare it to where you started.

Number shifted	Number did not shift
Do another round on the same issue.	Get more specific — name the exact sensation, not just the emotion.
If you are at 3 or below, move to a positive closing round.	Check your setup statement — does it feel honest in your body?
Notice where in your body the feeling has softened.	Try a different reminder phrase, one that feels more precise.
Stay with it until you reach 0–2.	Some issues have layers. One more round.
Anchor with a positive statement at the end.	If nothing moves after 3 rounds, set it down and return tomorrow.